of the US, to get the Russian Ural Airlines to bring the voluminous documents and hardware to India. Of the four scheduled consignments from Moscow, three had landed in Trivandrum between 23 January and 17 July 1994. The last one was to come in December 1994. However, before that the ISRO spy case was fabricated.

Some people were clearly not happy also with India flying its first satellite launch vehicle; they knew India would barge into the commercial satellite launch market with high competent prices (as less as half an American launch) if it acquired cryogenic technology. Then Prime Minister P V Narasimha Rao put it mildly during a discussion in the Parliament, indicating the 'involvement of a foreign country' in thwarting the Russian cryogenic contract.

Six respectable people—Satish Dhawan, T N Seshan, U R Rao, Yash Pal, R Narasimha and S Chandrashekar—had this to say in an open letter after the Kerala Government ordered 'further investigation' in the case even after the Chief Judicial Magistrate had accepted the CBI report and absolved all the accused of the charges: 'The "espionage case" reveals that the country's space programme or for that matter other strategic programmes, may no longer be immune to outside interference.'

So, were the IB officers pawns or active foot soldiers in this interested party's international board game? It will be tough to say 'no' if you look at the systematic way in which the US imposed sanctions to scuttle the cryogenic technology transfer from Russia to India only two years earlier, and the way in which Dhar and a few other IB officers decided on the espionage angle, even before they started investigation.

American intelligence is known for penetrating a developing country's intelligence network by targeting two kinds of people: young officers and those on the verge of retirement. They believe some youngsters in crucial Indian departments can be 'cultivated', and, as they grow in their diplomatic career, can be a valuable asset for the US intelligence. India's counter intelligence strategists are well aware of this cat-and-mouse game; this is why R&AW keeps shuffling its decks, especially at the bottom.